

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 244

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

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Section Title(S): MODESTY

MODESTY

The !Kung are modest in the presence of anybody, not just the persons to whom they accord reserved behavior. Nevertheless, I think it is possible to interpret their modesty, like the avoidance of joking, as demonstrating the restraint required by the incest taboo. The !Kung live close together, without privacy, without walls, constantly in each other's sight, and they are likely to be regularly in the presence of relatives to whom the incest taboo applies, before whom any visible expression of sexuality would be improper. From this, I believe, their modest behavior has developed.

[834
General Sex
Restrictions](#)

[835
Kinship Regulation Of
Sex](#)

The !Kung constantly kiss their babies, but adults do not embrace or kiss in public view. They conduct their sexual intercourse with extreme discretion.

[834
General Sex
Restrictions](#)

They are exceedingly careful to keep their genitalia covered. The men are never without their breechclouts. When I several times dressed a very bad boil in Short Gao's groin, he took such precautions to keep himself covered that I could hardly manage to bandage him properly. His friends thought this very funny and leaned over us snickering and joking. The women wear a modesty apron hanging from their waists in front and a small skin tied around their waists, hanging down in back or drawn up between their legs, in addition to their large karosses. They tuck their garments around them when they sit, and they sit in modest posture. Their breasts are bare; breasts are associated with nursing, not sex. Buttocks, however, are definitely associated with sex. A common position for sexual intercourse is for the man to lie at the back of the

[291
Normal Garb](#)

[516
Postures](#)

[832
Sexual Stimulation](#)

[833
Sexual Intercourse](#)

woman. The word "back" is part of the vocabulary of sex. If it is said that a woman has a "good back," it means that she does not become pregnant too often. We wanted the women to take off their karosses and back aprons so that we could observe the presence or absence of steatopygia among them. We also wanted them to take off their karosses, as they customarily do, when they danced the Eland Dance of the first menstruation rite for us. In both instances they were highly offended and vehemently refused to do what we asked.

834
General Sex
Restrictions

881
Puberty And Initiation

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